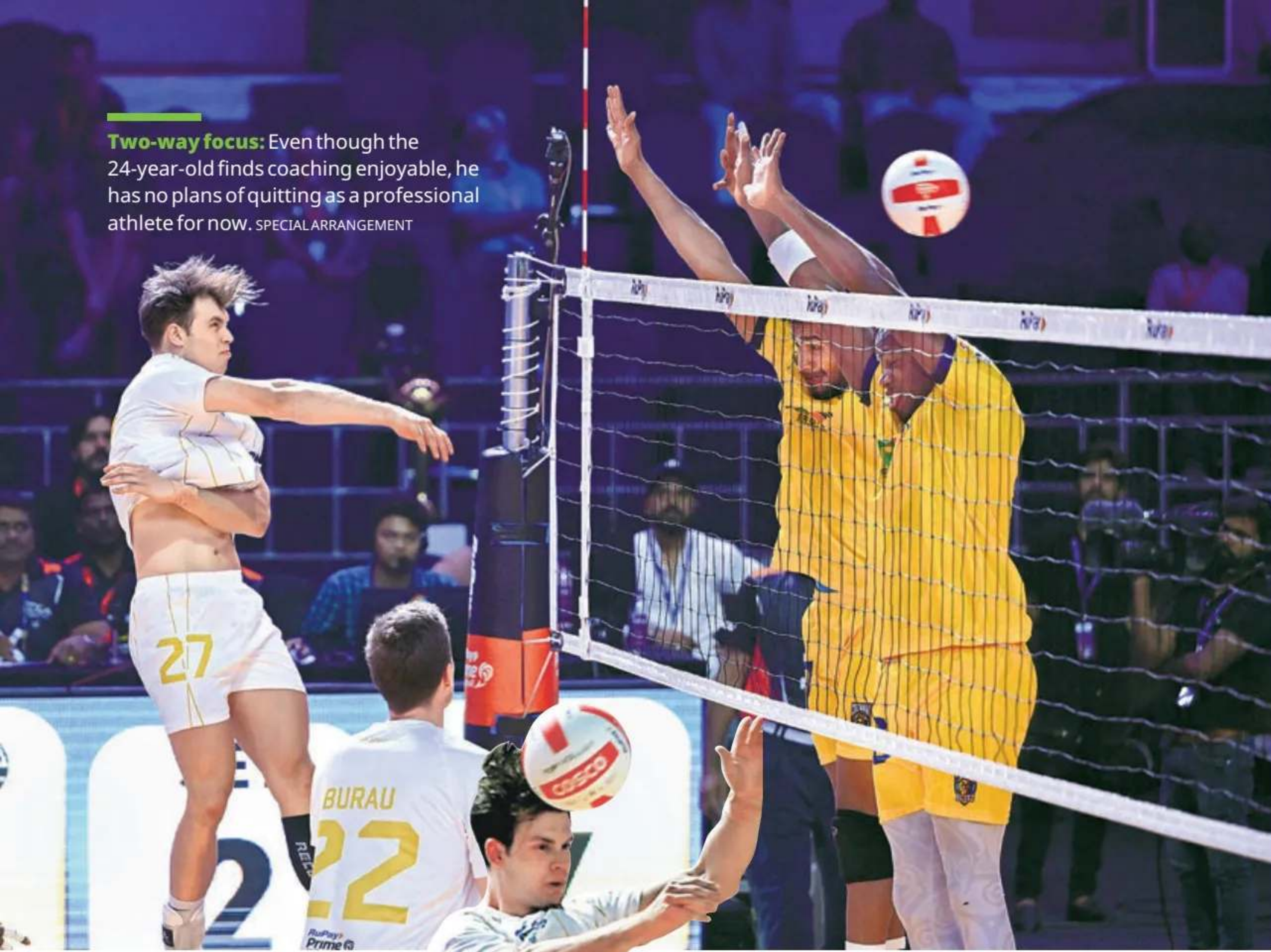


Two-way focus: Even though the 24-year-old finds coaching enjoyable, he has no plans of quitting as a professional athlete for now. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



thinking about the sport and our role within the team. I think both coaches (Dakshinamoorthy and Dragan) have a good variety of lessons that can set us up for success, but at the moment, I'm enjoying working with Dragan," said the Australian.

The competitive training spirit keeps Senica and his teammates on their toes, as none are guaranteed a starting six spot.

The 24-year-old said, "No player is guaranteed a position on the court at any time, which is the best thing that can be for any professional team. You don't want players making it easy at training. The best thing about our team is that we are all highly competitive and want to be in the starting six."

The Aussie contrast

While the push to outperform keeps Senica and the team together, it's the

creativity and aggressive approach to the game that the international wants to imbibe from his Indian teammates.

Praising the Defenders captain, Muthusamy Appavu, for his ingenuity, Senica said, "The players here tend to be a lot more aggressive. Muthu is very creative, and his playing style is not generic. European volleyball tends to follow a system without much deviation, but he (Muthu) likes to play around a bit, and I enjoy that."

Senica is also envious of the flexibility of the Indian players, wishing to learn and emulate it in his training and

coaching programmes.

Since he started coaching two years ago, his motto of keeping the conversation honest and realistic remains unchanged.

"I like to reiterate to athletes to work with 99 per cent of everything they do in their sports career, because nobody is going to see or care. It's only when you step on the court that everyone is watching."

Even though the 24-year-old finds coaching enjoyable, he has no plans of quitting as a professional athlete.

Senica, confident of the Defenders retaining the title, has planned the rest of his year following PVL 3. "After we win the tournament, I'll have some time off," he said.

After which he will join the Australian squad for the 2025 World Championship qualifiers and also look to secure a spot in the Volleyball Nations League. "It's a big and important season for the Australian team," he concluded.

M. VEDHAN